

SHELF LIFE

written by

Joshua Brooks

FADE IN:

**INT. DALE'S KITCHEN -- HIGH DESERT, CALIFORNIA -- MORNING
[AFTER]**

A kitchen organized like a submarine galley. Labeled canisters in rows. A wall-mounted radio. A laminated card by the stove: SHUT-OFF VALVE LOCATIONS.

DALE HARMON, 47, broad, careful, a man built like a load-bearing wall, is making a school lunch with a VACUUM SEALER.

He seals a peanut butter sandwich into a plastic brick. Sets it beside: a sealed brick of carrot sticks, a sealed brick of Goldfish crackers, and an emergency mylar blanket folded to the size of a playing card.

NORA, 9, backpack on, watches from the doorway with the flat patience of a child who has chosen her battles.

NORA

The other kids' sandwiches aren't
in bricks.

DALE

The other kids' sandwiches are
stale by ten a.m.

NORA

Marisol's mom uses a Ziploc.

DALE

(sealing the juice box --
the juice box -- into
plastic)
A Ziploc isn't rated for
anything.

NORA

It's rated for sandwiches.

Dale considers this. Slides the sealed bricks into her lunchbox, which has a carabiner on it, and a whistle.

DALE

Emergency blanket stays in the
bottom. You don't have to use it.
It just lives there.

NORA

(taking the lunchbox;
heading for the door; over
her shoulder, deadly)
Marisol asked if my family was in
the army and I said no, my uncle
is just like this.

The door bangs. Dale stands in the galley kitchen, alone,
holding the vacuum sealer.

He looks at it.

DALE

(to the sealer)
A Ziploc isn't rated for
anything.

CUT TO:

INT. LUZ CAFE -- BAKERSFIELD -- DAY [THE YEAR -- SPRING]

SUPER: "SPRING"

A strip-mall Mexican diner. Formica, sugar packets, a TV
playing daytime court shows on mute. CASS HARMON, 43 --
Dale's sister, wiry, quick, the fast-talking one to his
slow one, a hospital cafeteria hairnet pushed up on her
head like a tiara -- sits across from Dale in a booth. Two
menudos. She hasn't touched hers.

CASS

Okay so don't do the thing.

DALE

What thing.

CASS

The thing you do. Where I say something and your face doesn't move and then you go home and buy four hundred dollars of tarps.

DALE

That was one time, and the tarps were on clearance --

CASS

Dale.

Something in her voice. He stops. The court show plays silently over her shoulder: someone being awarded damages.

CASS (CONT'D)

They found a thing. On the scan. It's in the pancreas, which -- I already looked it up, don't look it up, the internet is a horror movie --

(she rotates her coffee cup a quarter turn; her tell; he knows it and we will learn it)

They're saying months. Plural, which is nice. Nobody would commit to a number of months, so I've decided it's a lot. I've decided it's like, forty months.

A long silence. Dale's face doesn't move.

CASS (CONT'D)

You're doing the thing.

DALE

I'm not doing the thing.

CASS

Your face is a parking lot, Dale.
Say words.

DALE

(and his first words, after
his sister says she is
dying, are:)
Which hospital? Because Kern
Medical's generators are twenty
years old, I've seen the specs,
if there's a grid event
mid-treatment --

CASS

(putting her hand flat on
the table; not angry; this
is the reaction she
expected, planned around,
maybe even needed)
There it is.

DALE

Cass --

CASS

No -- it's fine. It's you. You
heard "dying" and you went
straight to the generators.
(she finally picks up her
spoon; eats a bite of
menudo, because her body
still gets hungry, which
offends her)
Everybody else is going to cry on
me for six months. You're going
to inspect generators.
(beat)
Honestly? I picked the right
person to tell first.

INT. HARMON HOUSE -- KITCHEN -- NIGHT [1989]

SUPER: "1989"

A different kitchen -- avocado appliances, a wall phone with a long tangled cord. YOUNG DALE, 11, husky, serious, stands on a chair at the counter with a flashlight, a box of saltines, a can of soup, and a whistle, arranging them in a shoebox with terrible precision.

YOUNG CASS, 7, gap-toothed, watches from the table, coloring.

YOUNG CASS

What's it for?

YOUNG DALE

It's a kit.

YOUNG CASS

What's a kit?

YOUNG DALE

It's for if something happens.

Down the hall, through a door ajar: a bedroom lamp, and the sound of their MOTHER coughing -- long, wet, wrong, the cough of a thirty-eight-year-old woman with something nobody has named in front of the children yet.

Young Dale stops arranging. Listens until the cough ends. Then keeps arranging.

YOUNG CASS

(coloring; not looking up)

Is something gonna happen?

YOUNG DALE

(aligning the whistle

parallel to the flashlight)

Not if there's a kit.

The logic of an eleven-year-old, laid out in a shoebox: if you prepare for the thing, the thing can't happen. The film will spend two hours dismantling this sentence.

INT. DALE'S HOUSE -- GARAGE -- NIGHT [THE YEAR -- SPRING]

The garage does not contain a car. It contains STEEL SHELVING to the ceiling: water barrels, ammo cans of documents, buckets labeled in Dale's block handwriting -- RICE 2041, BEANS 2039, LASAGNA (25 YR) -- rows of them, a supermarket for a customer base of one.

Dale, home from the diner, stands in the middle of it. Jacket still on. Keys still in his hand.

He stands there a long time.

Then he takes a legal pad off a shelf, sits on a bucket of beans, and begins to write. We see the heading:

INSERT -- LEGAL PAD: "CASS -- CONTINGENCIES." Below it, a numbered list already growing: "1. Second opinion (UCLA? Stanford?) 2. Transport redundancy -- if truck down, backup vehicle 3. Generator specs Kern Med 4. Freezer meals -- 90 day rotation 5."

He stops at 5. The pen hovers.

Number 5 is the one that has no words. He writes nothing. He goes back and underlines "Freezer meals" twice.

This is a man calming himself, and it looks exactly like a man planning a rescue, and the film would like you to notice that from here on you cannot tell those two things apart. Neither can he.

INT. NORA'S SCHOOL -- PICKUP LINE -- DAY [AFTER]

Dale's pickup truck idles in a line of crossover SUVs like a bear at a dog park. Nora climbs in, drops her backpack in the footwell.

NORA

We're doing family trees. I need photos.

DALE

(pulling out, checking mirrors twice)

Of who?

NORA

Family. That's the tree part.
(beat; looking out the
window; the too-casual voice
of a nine-year-old handling
explosives)
Ms. Okafor said I can do the tree
"however feels right." She said
it in the voice. Everybody knows
the voice.

Dale drives. His jaw works once.

DALE

We got photos. There's a whole
ammo can of photos.

NORA

Our family pictures are in an
ammo can.

DALE

It's waterproof, fireproof, and
it stacks.

NORA

(looking out the window;
quietly; not a complaint,
just data)
Marisol's are in an album shaped
like a heart.

DALE

(beat; changing lanes with
enormous care)
Ziploc people.

**INT. KERN MEDICAL -- ONCOLOGY -- CONSULT ROOM -- DAY [THE
YEAR -- SPRING]**

Cass on the exam table in a paper gown she wears like a
heckler. Dale in the corner chair with the legal pad. DR.
VUONG, 40s, kind, precise, has clearly met a thousand

families and never one shaped quite like this.

DR. VUONG

-- so with this staging, the
honest conversation is about time
and quality of time. There are
treatment paths, and we'll talk
about all of them, but I don't
want to sell you a --

DALE

(from the corner; reading
off the pad)
What's the hospital's generator
capacity?

DR. VUONG

I'm -- sorry?

DALE

Backup power. If she's
mid-infusion and the grid fails.
It's a heat wave grid out here,
it fails every August. What's the
switchover time?

DR. VUONG

(genuinely trying)
I... believe there are redundant
systems --

DALE

"Believe" or know?

CASS

(to Dr. Vuong; pleasant;
jerking a thumb at Dale)
He's not insane, he's just like
this. Keep going, doctor. If the
power goes out he'll be
delighted, he's got a truck full

of extension cords.

DR. VUONG

(recalibrating; continuing)

The first decision point is
whether we pursue the aggressive
protocol --

And as she talks, the film stays on DALE, in the corner, writing everything down in block letters, filling the page, flipping it, filling the next -- a man taking dictation from a landslide. His notes are perfect. His hands are perfect. He is not okay, and the notes are how you can tell, and only one person in the room can read that language.

Cass, from the table, watches her brother write.

She lets him.

INT. HARMON HOUSE -- HALLWAY -- NIGHT [1989]

Young Dale, in pajamas, stands outside his mother's cracked bedroom door with the SHOEBOX KIT under his arm. Listens. No coughing right now. Just the TV inside, low.

He sets the kit down on the hallway floor, square against the door frame. Aligns it with the base board.

MOTHER (O.S.)

(from inside; warm, tired,
amused)

Dale Robert Harmon. Is that
another kit?

YOUNG DALE

(caught; to the door)

It's for you. There's a whistle.
If something happens and I'm at
school, you blow it and Mrs.
Petrakis next door --

MOTHER (O.S.)

Come in here.

Young Dale opens the door partway. We stay in the hall. We never enter this room, the whole film. Through the gap: lamplight, a shape in the bed, and a hand -- thin, freckled -- reaching out to take the shoebox from him, and holding his wrist for a second along with it.

MOTHER (O.S.) (CONT'D)

It's a good kit.

(beat)

Where's yours?

YOUNG DALE

(pause)

Mine?

MOTHER (O.S.)

You make everybody a kit, baby.

Where's yours?

Silence in the hallway. Young Dale looks at his own hands like they belong to the school lost-and-found. He has no answer. He will not have an answer for thirty-six years.

FADE OUT.

FADE IN:

**INT. HIGH DESERT SURPLUS & SUPPLY -- DAY [THE YEAR --
SPRING]**

A warehouse store for the worried: gun safes, water filtration, buckets of the future. Dale pushes a flatbed cart. Beside him, riding the end of the cart like a kid, because she is dying and store rules have stopped applying to her: CASS, in a beanie now -- round one of chemo has started collecting its fees.

CASS

(reading a bucket label)

"Chicken -- la King. Serves twelve. Shelf life: twenty-five years."

(to Dale)

Who is the customer for this?
Who's throwing a dinner party for twelve in the apocalypse?

DALE

It's not servings, it's calories.
You buy calories.

CASS

I'm just saying, -- la King is ambitious. The world ends and this bucket's like, "tonight -- a cream sauce."

A store EMPLOYEE, 20s, in a tactical vest that has never known danger beyond restocking, approaches.

EMPLOYEE

You folks finding everything? We got a promotion on the two-year med kits --

CASS

(bright)

Do you have anything for pancreatic cancer?

The employee's mouth opens. Stalls. Closes.

EMPLOYEE

...We have iodine tablets?

CASS

(nodding; grave)

Close.

The employee retreats. Dale gives Cass a look. Cass gives it right back, twice as hard.

CASS (CONT'D)

What? Everybody gets to be scared
of the end of the world in here
except me?

DALE

(pushing the cart; low)
You're not the end of the world.

CASS

(riding the cart; looking
down the aisle of buckets;
quieter, and for once not
joking fast enough to beat
the sincerity)
I'm the end of one.

The cart rolls past the buckets. Twenty-five-year lasagna.
Thirty-year oats. All this food for afters. Dale doesn't
answer. He puts a water filter on the cart that nobody
asked for.

**INT. CASS'S APARTMENT -- KITCHEN -- DAY [THE YEAR --
SPRING]**

A regular human kitchen: bills on the counter, a kid's
drawing on the fridge -- crayon family: CASS, NORA, and a
large rectangle-shaped man labeled "UNCLE DAIL." Dale
unloads groceries. Real ones -- produce, milk. His
versions of flowers.

Nora, at the table, does homework with the specific
loudness of a child listening to everything.

CASS

(putting away milk;
conversational; setting the
trap gently)
Saturday, you're taking us
somewhere.

DALE

Where?

CASS

Your bunker.

Dale stops, a can of soup in each hand.

DALE

It's not a bunker. It's a
reinforced --

CASS

Dale. I've known about it for six
years. Denny told Linda, Linda's
a talker. You bought the old
pistachio farm and you put
something under it.

(closing the fridge; facing
him)

Saturday. Full tour. Nora brings
a juice box, we make a day of it.

DALE

Why?

CASS

(and she holds his eyes just
one second too long before
she puts the smile back on)
Because I want to see where all
your money went, and because you
can't say no to me anymore. It's
the one good coupon this disease
comes with, and I am CLIPPING it.

NORA

(from the table; not looking
up)

What's a bunker?

CASS

It's a basement with self-esteem,
baby. Do your math.

**EXT. PISTACHIO FARM -- HIGH DESERT -- SATURDAY -- DAY [THE
YEAR -- SPRING]**

Dead trees in rows, a rusted water tank, a shipping container that isn't just a shipping container. Dale unlocks three locks. A steel staircase descends into cool dark.

INT. THE BUNKER -- CONTINUOUS

Lights hum on. And it's -- honestly -- kind of magnificent. A buried world: bunk room, kitchen shelf-wall, a rack of radios, an air system breathing softly. Everything labeled. Everything level. Ten years of a man's Sundays and most of his salary, arranged against the dark.

Nora runs in like it's a playground, immediately touching things.

NORA

Is this a SECRET? Are we in a
SECRET?

DALE

Filtration's there. Water's
gravity-fed from the tank.
Power's solar with a hand-crank
backup. Air scrubber's rated for
--

CASS

(walking slow, touching a
shelf edge, reading labels)
Rice, 2041. Beans, 2039.
(she stops; something on the
shelf catching her)
Dale.

She's looking at a section of shelving -- newer wood, different screws. Recently built. On it: kid-sized boots, a smaller sleeping bag, a bin labeled "N -- CLOTHES, SIZES 10-16." Sizes she hasn't grown into yet. A shelf for the future of a child, running years deep, like the rice.

Cass reads the label. Reads her daughter's future measured out in bin sizes. Her hand goes to her mouth for one second --

NORA (O.S.)
(from the bunk room; a
shriek of joy)
THERE'S A HAMMOCK!

-- and the moment is punctured, on schedule, and Cass laughs instead of the other thing, wet-eyed, and Dale pretends to check a gauge.

CASS
(quietly; not looking at
him; at the bin labels)
When did you build this part?

DALE
(checking the gauge; which
does not need checking)
Spring.

The word does its work. Spring. The diner. The menudo. He came home from learning she was dying and he built shelves for her daughter.

Cass nods slowly. Rotates an imaginary coffee cup a quarter turn.

CASS
Sit down, Dale.

DALE
The air system --

CASS
The air system's fine. Everything
in here is fine. It's the finest
room in Kern County. Sit.

He sits on a bunk. She sits across from him on a bucket of beans -- rhymes with the garage, and she doesn't know that, but the movie does. Somewhere off, Nora swings in

the hammock, singing something tuneless.

CASS (CONT'D)

Robbie's out. You know Robbie's out. He sends the checks and the birthday texts and that's the whole man, that's all the man there is.

(beat)

Mom's gone. Dad's -- wherever Dad is. Phoenix. Whatever.

(beat; here it comes; she says it the way you'd hand someone a live wire)

It has to be you.

Silence. The air system breathes.

DALE

(very quietly)

Cass, I vacuum-seal sandwiches.

CASS

I know.

DALE

I own four hundred pounds of rice and no album shaped like a heart. I've never -- I don't know what she needs. I know what she'd need if the grid fails. Nobody's ever needed what I have, Cass. That's the --

(and he stops, because he has never said the next sentence out loud, and he doesn't say it now either. He looks at the shelf wall instead. All of it. 2039. 2041.)

CASS

(watching him; gently; the
scene's turn)

You built a room under the ground
with sixteen years of her clothes
in it, Dale.

(beat)

You think I'm asking because
there's nobody else. I'm asking
because when I told you I was
dying, everybody else said
"anything you need." You went
home and I know for a fact you
sat in that garage and started a
list with my name on it.

(beat)

Show me the list.

DALE

(pause)

No.

CASS

Because it's forty pages?

DALE

(pause)

It's sixty pages.

CASS

(closing her eyes; a smile
breaking through like a
leak)

Sixty pages.

(she leans forward, takes
his hand off his knee, holds
it on top of the live wire)

That's the whole job, you giant
idiot. That's all parenting is.
It's a sixty-page list you never
finish, for a person you can't
protect, forever. You've been in
training your whole stupid life.

Off in the bunk room, the hammock creaks. Nora, upside down in it now, hair hanging:

NORA
(calling)
Can we live here?!

CASS
(calling back; eyes still on Dale)
No, baby. It's for emergencies.

NORA (O.S.)
What emergency?

Cass looks at Dale. Dale looks at Cass. Neither answers the child.

The air system breathes for everyone.

INT. KERN MEDICAL -- INFUSION CENTER -- DAY [THE YEAR -- SUMMER]

SUPER: "SUMMER"

Recliners in rows. IV poles. Cass in a chair, line in her arm, beanie on. Dale beside her in a hard chair with a cooler he packed at 5 AM.

He unpacks it, item by item, onto her tray table: sealed brick of crackers. Sealed ginger chews. A thermos labeled BROTH. A backup thermos labeled BROTH 2.

CASS
(watching the procession)
What's in Broth 2?

DALE
Broth.

CASS
What was wrong with Broth 1?

DALE

Nothing's wrong with Broth 1.
Broth 2 is if Broth 1 --

CASS

(to the NURSE passing by,
gesturing at Dale)
He has a backup broth.
(to Dale)
You know the other families
bring, like, a magazine?

DALE

(arranging the ginger chews
at a reachable angle; gruff;
this is the closest he can
get to saying it and they
both know it's exactly as
close as he can get)

Ziploc people.

Cass laughs -- and the laugh catches on the chemo nausea,
and turns into a long, bad moment, eyes shut, riding a
wave. Dale doesn't flinch. He's already there, basin in
one hand -- from the cooler, of course there's a basin in
the cooler -- other hand steady between her shoulder
blades. Not rubbing. Just present. A load-bearing hand.

The wave passes. She breathes.

CASS

(eyes still closed; hoarse;
quiet)
Okay. The broth thing's less
funny now.

DALE

(uncapping Broth 1; pouring)
It was never funny. It's a
protein delivery system.

CASS

(taking the cup with both
hands; small)
It's a little funny.

Around them, the infusion center hums -- a room full of
recliners, every one its own version of this scene, every
visitor's bag its own kind of kit. The film lets us see
the whole row for a moment: the husband with the crossword
he isn't doing, the daughter with the phone she isn't
reading. Everybody scared. Everybody caretaking. Same
posture.

INT. HARMON HOUSE -- LIVING ROOM -- DAY [1989]

The front door stands open to hard daylight. A DUFFEL BAG
waits by it.

THE FATHER, 40, jeans and a windbreaker, crouches to Young
Dale's height. Young Cass is on the stairs, watching
through the banister rails like a small prisoner.

FATHER
(low; man-to-man; the worst
speech ever given)
You're the guy now, okay? Look
after your mom. Look after
Cassie. You're good at that stuff
-- you're like me, you're
practical.
(he taps Dale's chest, once,
like installing something)
You're the guy.

He picks up the duffel and goes down the walk. He doesn't
look back, but he does adjust the bag strap twice, the
fidget of a man outrunning his own exit.

Young Dale stands in the doorway. Eleven years old. Newly
appointed.

Behind him, from the stairs:

YOUNG CASS
(matter-of-fact; seven)
Is he coming back?

YOUNG DALE
(watching the car pull out;
and here's the boy building
the man in one line, block
letters, laminated)
Doesn't matter. We have a kit.

FADE OUT.

FADE IN:

INT. DALE'S HOUSE -- NORA'S ROOM -- NIGHT [AFTER]

A kid's room mid-colonization: half moving boxes, half installed life. A reading lamp. Glow stars on the ceiling in astronomically incorrect positions that someone was not permitted to correct.

Dale, laundry basket under one arm, opens the closet to put away folded clothes -- and stops.

On the closet floor, tucked behind the shoe rack: a BACKPACK. Not her school one. Packed hard, zippers straining.

He shouldn't. He does.

Inside: a flashlight. Two vacuum-sealed sandwich bricks, stolen from his own kitchen. A rolled t-shirt. Four granola bars. A juice box. A whistle -- her lunchbox whistle, transferred. And a folded piece of paper, crayon on it: the family drawing off Cass's old fridge -- CASS, NORA, UNCLE DAIL -- creased into eighths, protected in the middle of everything, like documents.

A go-bag. A nine-year-old's go-bag.

Dale sits down slowly on the edge of her bed with the backpack on his knees, and the film stays on his face while a man watches his own childhood arrive by return mail. It is the exact kit from 1989 -- his kit, reinvented independently, two generations of scared children packing calories against the dark.

The bathroom door opens down the hall -- water running, Nora's off-key humming. Dale moves fast: repacks it exactly -- sandwich bricks, bars, whistle, drawing folded back into eighths -- zips it, sets it behind the shoe rack at its original angle.

Nora pads in, toothpaste-breathed, and climbs into bed. Dale is innocently holding laundry.

NORA

You're doing the statue thing in my room.

DALE

Putting away clothes.

NORA

(getting under the covers;
watching him with Cass's
exact eyes)

Okay.

He turns off the big light. Pauses at the door.

DALE

(not looking at the closet;
carefully, into the dark)
You know if anything ever -- if
there's ever a problem, any kind.
You come get me. That's the whole
plan. I'm the plan.

NORA

(already half-asleep;
devastating in the way only
the half-asleep can manage)
I know. You're the plan.
(beat)
I have a backup plan.

Dale stands in the doorway a long moment.

DALE

(quietly)
Yeah. Okay.

He pulls the door to. In the hallway, alone, he leans his back against the wall next to her door -- the exact geometry of a hallway from 1989 -- and stays there a while, on watch, guarding against nothing that can be guarded against.

INT. CASS'S APARTMENT -- LIVING ROOM -- DAY [THE YEAR -- FALL]

SUPER: "FALL"

The apartment has grown medical equipment the way rooms do -- a hospital bed where the couch angle used to be, an oxygen concentrator chugging in the corner like a patient aquarium. Cass, smaller now, sharper-boned, holds court from the bed with a legal pad OF HER OWN.

Dale is installing a grab bar in the hallway. Drill in hand. Third grab bar today.

CASS
(reading from her pad)
Item one. The funeral. No
slideshow. I mean it, Dale, if
there's a slideshow set to
acoustic music I will haunt you
specifically --

DALE
(from the hallway; drilling)
No slideshow.

CASS
Item two. Nora keeps her last
name. Robbie will not surface
about this but if he surfaces --

DALE
He won't surface.

CASS

Item three.

(beat; and her voice changes
gear, and the drill stops)
The school has a counselor, her
name's Ms. Okafor, she's good,
Nora likes her, the file's
already open. Tuesdays. You keep
the Tuesdays, Dale. Whatever else
falls apart, the Tuesdays are
load-bearing.

Dale comes to the doorway, drill still in hand, dust on
his forearms.

DALE

(gruff)
You're making a list.

CASS

I'm making YOUR list. Sixty
pages. I'm starting it for you.
(she pats the bed; he
doesn't move; she pats it
again, harder, and he comes
and sits, drill and all)
Item four.

She sets the pad down. Item four isn't on the pad.

CASS (CONT'D)

When it happens -- and we're past
"if," we're deep into "when," the
doctors have stopped doing the
weather-report voice --
(beat)
-- you're going to want to build
something. That week. I know you.
You'll want to pour a foundation.
Buy a decade of something.

DALE

(looking at the drill in his
hands)
Cass --

CASS

Let me finish, I rehearsed this.

(beat)

Build if you have to. Buy the buckets. I'm not going to fix you from a hospital bed, that's arrogant.

(she takes his wrist -- the same grip as a freckled hand through a door in 1989, and the film trusts us to feel the rhyme without a flashback)

But every bucket you buy, you look at it once and you ask it one question. Out loud. I want you to promise the out-loud part, because in your head you cheat.

DALE

What question?

CASS

"Is this for her -- or is this for it?"

(beat)

Her, you keep. It -- the fear, the whole roaring thing you've been feeding since you were eleven -- it doesn't get my daughter. It got you. It's not getting her.

A long silence. The oxygen concentrator chugs. Dale looks at his sister -- at the pad, at the bed rails he installed, at the grab bars marching down the hallway, at everything he has built between her and the dark, none of it working, all of it necessary.

DALE

(the most words he's said at once in the whole film, and

every one costs a dollar)
When Mom was sick I made her a
kit. Saltines and a whistle. I
figured -- if the kit's there,
the thing can't happen. That was
the deal I made. Nobody signed it
but me.

(beat)

The thing happened anyway. And I
remember standing in the hallway
thinking: the kit was wrong. Not
the deal -- the KIT. Wrong
crackers. Something. So I got
better at kits.

(beat; he looks at her;
forty-seven years old and
eleven)

I'm still doing it. I know I'm
still doing it. I got a room
under a pistachio farm that can
keep two hundred people alive for
a year, Cass, and I can't --

He stops. The sentence arrives at the wall it has been
driving toward his whole life.

CASS

(softly; finishing it
because someone finally has
to)

-- and you can't keep me.

The words land in the room and just sit there, true.

CASS (CONT'D)

(beat; and then, because no
moment in this family is
allowed to sit in sincerity
longer than it can stand)

Two hundred people? Who ARE these
people? You don't LIKE two
hundred people. You like maybe
four people. Three. It's three,
Dale.

DALE

(wiping his eyes with the
back of the drill hand;
rough; grateful for the
exit)

It's a calorie calculation.

CASS

You built Noah's Ark for a man
with three friends.

DALE

(standing; back to the grab
bar; voice not quite steady)

Item five. What's item five.

CASS

(picking the pad back up;
and her voice isn't quite
steady either, and neither
of them mentions it, which
is how this family says
everything)

Item five. Teach her to drive
when it's time. On the truck.
Nobody learns anything on a
Prius.

**INT. CASS'S APARTMENT -- KITCHEN -- NIGHT [THE YEAR --
WINTER]**

SUPER: "WINTER"

The kitchen, late. Dale cooks -- actually cooks, real
food, a pot of something careful -- while filling labeled
deli containers in rows on every counter. Dozens of them.
TUES LUNCH. WEDS DINNER. The masking-tape genealogy of
love in this family.

Through the doorway, in the living room: Nora, in pajamas,
is curled on the hospital bed next to Cass -- both asleep,
television still going, a cooking-show blue washing over
them. Cass's arm is around her daughter. On the bedside
table, Cass's legal pad, pages of it filled now.

Dale comes to the doorway with the wooden spoon in his hand. Looks at them a long time.

Then he goes back into the kitchen and keeps filling containers, quietly, so quietly, the ladle touched to each rim so it doesn't ring against the plastic. A man in an apron building a seawall out of soup, one pint at a time, all night if the pot holds out.

The film holds the doorway between the two rooms -- the sleeping and the cooking, the dying and the preparing -- in the same frame.

INT. CASS'S APARTMENT -- DAY [AFTER -- THE BEGINNING OF AFTER]

Boxes. The hospital bed is gone -- a rectangle of unfaded carpet where it stood, the exact ghost-geometry of the plaque dust and the bench screw holes of other stories, and of this one.

Dale wraps dishes in newspaper, alone. Slow. Nothing efficient about him today, first time in the film.

He opens the freezer to empty it -- and stops.

The freezer is FULL. His containers. TUES LUNCH. WEDS DINNER. Weeks of them, untouched, going back into fall. She stopped being able to eat long before she told him. She let him keep cooking anyway.

Dale stands in the cold breath of the open freezer, reading masking-tape labels in his own block handwriting, understanding -- all at once, the way these things arrive -- that the meals were never a protein delivery system. She'd known that from the first container. She let him fill her freezer for the same reason a mother once let a boy leave a shoebox at her door.

Because the kit was never for the person it was labeled for.

Dale closes the freezer. Rests his forehead against it. One breath. Two.

From the doorway:

NORA (O.S.)

Uncle Dale?

He straightens. Turns. Nora, 9, in the doorway of her own emptied home, backpack on both shoulders. The backpack.

NORA (CONT'D)

Which car do I go in?

And that's the whole custody arrangement, the whole future, the whole third act, in five words from a kid in a doorway.

DALE

(steady; because for her he
can be; that's the discovery
of his life happening in
real time)

Mine.

FADE OUT.

FADE IN:

INT. DALE'S HOUSE -- HALLWAY / NORA'S ROOM -- 2:14 AM
[AFTER]

Dark. A small sound wakes the house -- a whimper, a cough. Dale is in the hallway in eleven seconds, a man who has clearly slept dressed for years.

Nora, in bed, flushed, glassy, miserable.

NORA

(small)

I don't feel good.

Dale's hand goes to her forehead. Hot. Genuinely hot.

And watch him: the machine spins up. This -- THIS -- he has trained for. He is gone and back in forty seconds with a medical kit the size of carry-on luggage. Thermometer -- the good one, the temporal artery one. 102.8.

DALE

Okay. Okay.

(opening the kit; ampules,
instruments, a suture set, a
POCKET GUIDE TO AUSTERE
MEDICINE)

Okay.

He looks at the kit. The kit contains: a tourniquet. Water purification. Israeli battle dressings. QuikClot. Burn gel. Fish antibiotics, three kinds.

The kit does not contain: children's Tylenol.

Dale stares into the carry-on-sized hole in his life's preparation. Fourteen thousand dollars of readiness, rated for gunshot wounds and grid collapse, and the emergency is 102.8 in a nine-year-old, and the answer is a purple syrup sold at every gas station in America, and he doesn't have it.

NORA

(from the pillow; watching
him stare into the bag)

Do I need the tourniquet?

DALE

(closing the bag)

No.

NORA

(closing her eyes; even at
102.8 the timing is her
mother's)

This is a bad kit.

INT. 24-HOUR PHARMACY -- BAKERSFIELD -- 2:51 AM

Fluorescent purgatory. Dale moves down the children's aisle like a man defusing it, phone in hand, on with the NIGHT NURSE LINE.

DALE

(into phone)

-- 102.8 temporal, re-checked
twice, onset roughly ninety
minutes ago, no rash, lungs
clear, she's --

(beat)

-- I put my ear on her back. I
don't own a stethoscope.

(beat; quieter; the
admission of the entire
film)

I own everything else.

NIGHT NURSE (V.O.)

(kind; been doing this
thirty years)

Sir, it sounds like a fever. Kids
get them. Alternate acetaminophen
and ibuprofen, fluids, call your
pediatrician in the morning.
She's going to be fine.

DALE

(standing in the aisle, a
bottle of purple syrup in
each hand, not moving)

"Fine."

NIGHT NURSE (V.O.)

Fine. This is the most normal
call I'll get tonight.

Dale looks at the purple bottles. Something lets go in his
shoulders -- not relief exactly. Scale. The emergency is
small. The emergency was always going to be small.
Emergencies mostly are, and they come anyway, purple syrup
and Tuesdays, and no bunker has a shelf for them.

DALE

(into phone; gruff)

What's the dosage by weight?
She's sixty-one pounds.

NIGHT NURSE (V.O.)

It's on the box, hon.

DALE

I'd rather hear it from a person.

A pause on the line. Thirty years of night calls, and something in that sentence lands with her anyway.

NIGHT NURSE (V.O.)

(gentler)

Yeah, okay. Got a pen?

DALE

(already writing on his palm
in block letters)

Go.

INT. DALE'S HOUSE -- NORA'S ROOM -- 3:40 AM

Nora, dosed, sweaty, asleep. The fever doing its ordinary work. Dale sits on the floor beside her bed, back against the nightstand, a cup of the purple syrup's little dosage cup on his knee like a shot glass.

He's not on his phone. Not reading a manual. Just sitting. On watch. The one supply he's always had in surplus.

His eyes drift to the closet. The shoe rack. The go-bag behind it.

A long moment. Then, moving quietly, he pulls the go-bag out, opens it, and -- item by item -- unpacks it. Sandwich bricks back to the kitchen pile. Granola bars to the pantry pile. He works gently, repacking her fear into household shelves where it can just be food again.

At the bottom: the whistle, and the folded crayon drawing. CASS, NORA, UNCLE DAIL.

The whistle he holds a long time.

He doesn't take it. He puts the whistle back in the empty bag, alone, with the drawing -- and leaves the bag where it was, behind the shoe rack. Lighter by everything except the two things that were never supplies.

Some kits you don't confiscate. You just quietly cancel the emergency they were packed for, one Tuesday at a time.

INT. NORA'S SCHOOL -- COUNSELOR'S OFFICE -- DAY [AFTER]

MS. OKAFOR, 50s, cardigan, unhurried eyes, sits across a small table from Dale, who occupies the child-adjacent chair like a bear at a tea party. Between them: Nora's FAMILY TREE project.

It is not a tree. It is a diagram of the BUNKER -- cross-section, crayon, meticulous -- and in the bunk room, three figures: NORA, UNCLE DAIL, and above them, not in the bunker but drawn into the dirt and grass OVER it, arms out flat like a superhero mid-flight, or like someone lying on a lawn looking up: MOM.

MS. OKAFOR

She presented it to the class. I want you to hear how she explained it, because I think you should have it word for word.

(reading from a sticky note, carefully)

"My mom doesn't fit inside anymore, so she's the ground. The ground is how the bunker stays a bunker. It holds the roof on."

Dale looks at the drawing for a very long time. The crayon woman in the earth, arms out, holding the roof on.

MS. OKAFOR (CONT'D)

Tuesdays are working, Mr. Harmon. I wanted you to know. Whatever you're doing at home --

DALE

(still looking at the drawing; hoarse)

I'm mostly just there.

MS. OKAFOR

(nodding; sliding the
drawing across the table for
him to keep; the
professional summary of the
entire movie, delivered
mildly, between
appointments)
That's the active ingredient.
Everything else is packaging.

**INT. HARMON HOUSE -- KITCHEN -- NIGHT [1989 -- FINAL
FRAGMENT]**

The avocado kitchen, one last time. Later that year --
winter light, a casserole dish on the counter from some
neighbor, the house in the hushed aftermath the film has
never shown and doesn't now.

Young Dale, in a clip-on tie, sits at the table. In front
of him: the SHOEBOX KIT, returned to him, the way
hospitals return belongings. The saltines. The flashlight.
The whistle.

Young Cass, 7, in a stiff dress, climbs onto the chair
beside him. Looks at the box. Looks at her brother's face,
which is a parking lot.

She takes the whistle out of the box. Turns it over. And
then -- seven years old, in a funeral dress, in the
quietest house in California -- she blows it. Loud.
Shrill. Absurd. A referee calling a foul on the universe.

Young Dale stares at her.

She blows it again, right at him, cheeks out, defiant,
until -- there -- the corner of his mouth. She hands him
the whistle. He looks at it.

He blows it. Tentative. Then really. Then they're BOTH
doing it, trading it, blasting this stupid whistle in
their funeral clothes in the empty kitchen, two orphaned
kids sounding an alarm about everything, until it
collapses into the kind of laughing that is also the other
thing.

The whistle was never for Mrs. Petrakis next door. It was
never for emergencies.

It was so somebody would come. And somebody did. They came for each other, whistle-first, for the next thirty-six years.

INT. DALE'S KITCHEN -- EVENING [AFTER -- WINTER]

SUPER: "TUESDAY"

The galley kitchen, softened by months: a kid's drawing taped over the SHUT-OFF VALVE card. A heart-shaped photo album on the counter, half-filled, next to the ammo can it's slowly emptying.

On the table, steaming in a casserole dish: dinner. Nora eyes it.

NORA

What is it?

DALE

Lasagna.

NORA

From where?

DALE

(beat)

The garage.

NORA

(fork frozen)

The BUCKET lasagna? The twenty-five-year lasagna?

DALE

Twenty-five-year SHELF LIFE. It's four years old. It's basically new.

NORA

Why are we eating the apocalypse food? Is something happening?

And Dale sets down the serving spoon, and answers her honestly, which is the entire distance this man has traveled:

DALE

No. Nothing's happening.

(beat)

That's the occasion.

Nora considers this -- considers him -- and takes a bite. Chews. The verdict assembles.

NORA

(chewing)

...It's not terrible.

DALE

High praise.

NORA

It's like regular lasagna that's scared of you.

Dale barks a laugh -- an actual laugh, ambushed out of him, the first of the film -- and Nora grins at having caused it, and they eat the emergency, one fork at a time, on a Tuesday, for no reason, which is the best reason.

On the counter, faintly ridiculous in the domestic light: the vacuum sealer. Unplugged. There's a Ziploc box next to it.

EXT. PISTACHIO FARM -- HIGH DESERT -- DAY [AFTER -- SPRING]

SUPER: "SPRING"

One year since a diner booth in Bakersfield. The dead orchard, the shipping container, the whole buried kingdom -- and on the grass above it, exactly where a crayon drawing put a flying woman: a PICNIC BLANKET.

Dale and Nora eat sandwiches on it. Regular sandwiches. In Ziplocs.

NORA
(looking at the container
door)
Do we still have it? Everything
under there?

DALE
We still have it.

NORA
Good.
(lying back on the blanket,
hands behind her head, her
mother's exact gesture on
her mother's exact ground)
But we don't have to go in.

DALE
(lying back too; to the sky)
No. We don't have to go in.

Wind through dead pistachio rows. Somewhere below them,
sixteen years of shelves keep their long, patient vigil,
rated for everything except what actually happens,
guarding a boy's old promise in the cool dark. Let them.
Some things you don't dismantle. You just move the picnic
upstairs.

Nora fishes in her jacket pocket. Comes out with the
WHISTLE. She's had it all along.

She blows it -- one short, bright, pointless blast across
the empty orchard. A referee calling a foul on the
universe. A kid making a noise because she can.

She hands it to Dale.

He looks at it. Thirty-six years of alarm.

He blows it. Long. Loud. For absolutely no one, about
absolutely nothing, needed by nobody --

-- which is, at last, the whole point.

The sound carries out over the orchard and the desert
takes it, easily, the way it takes everything, and the two
of them lie back on the ground that holds the roof on.

FADE OUT.

THE END